



In the mind: Lakshya Sen's coach, Vimal Kumar, believes that his recent decline in form was mainly due to his mindset rather than his physical abilities. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

be patient, and [he isn't]. He's a little anxious; that's also an issue. Every athlete goes through this, but he's taking time to come out of it."

For now, at least, it seems Lakshya has found his way out of the maze.

It's true that some work still needs to be done. Lakshya admitted as much following his loss in the semifinals at All England.

Although he had seemingly swung the momentum with a dominant second game against Christie, the Indonesian found a second wind in the decider, which Lakshya wasn't able to match. **Despite having won two consecutive three-game matches in the run-up to the semifinal, it was clear that the Indian was not quite as quick towards the end of his match against Christie.** Net shots that would usually kiss the net and fall on the other side were now being lifted a few extra inches, giving Christie just enough time to hit winners.

The reason was obvious. While Lakshya had been drained after spending two and a half hours of high-intensity badminton in the two days before his semifinal, Christie

had spent just one hour and 33 minutes (owing to China's Shi Yuqi pulling out after the first game in his quarterfinal match) on the court.

"All the matches that I've played were long, and I could feel it in the recovery and the next day's match preparation," Lakshya would say in the BWF mixed zone after the defeat. "Some matches, I started slow in the first set, even having a good lead and then not being able to convert those first-setters that then went on to three games. I won some of those, but I know this is one thing that I want to improve: close matches in two games. So that I'm a bit fresher," he would say.

For a player who's no stranger to

success at the international level and who has made the final at All England previously, a semifinal finish did indeed leave him a little unsatisfied, but he's able to see the bigger picture as well.

"I'm pretty disappointed with the result. **But overall, the way I played over two weeks, surely I have the level to be up there and win in the big tournaments,**" Lakshya said. "I'll discuss with my coaches and try to analyse the two weeks much better because, as of now, I was just focusing on the next match after every game. Now it's time to reflect and watch those matches again. Take good things and keep learning from the mistakes," Lakshya said.

HAVING FOUND HIMSELF IN A RICH VEIN OF FORM, LAKSHYA NOW HAS A SIGNIFICANT TAILWIND BEHIND HIM HEADING INTO THE OLYMPICS